

## Chapter 37-1: Chu Qingqiu

"Good that you know." Feng Ge looked at her, then waved her hand to lead the other disciples straight into the dense forest of shrubs. Hong Ying wanted to say something more but finally shook his head. Just as he was about to step forward to follow, he suddenly noticed that Rong Jin and Liu Wenzhu were still standing in place.

"What are you doing?" he said roughly.

"Since senior brothers and sisters are unwilling to bring Ning Fuyi, then we won't go either. After all, our cultivation can't compare to yours either. We're afraid of dragging everyone down!" Rong Jin's face turned cold as he took the bow and arrows off his shoulder while speaking.

"You...!" Hong Ying was also somewhat angry now. He looked back at the group that had already gone far, then looked at Rong Jin with frustration. "Fine! If you're willing to give up this opportunity yourselves, I can't help it!"

With that, he suddenly turned around, his body transforming into a blur as he left this place.

The dense forest became quiet. Ning Fuyi sighed and said: "Wenzhu, Senior Brother, you really don't need to stay with me."

"When the sect leader was here, he taught us that in this vast martial world, fellow disciples should support each other as wings, never abandoning each other. How can we abandon fellow disciples for the sake of getting a few more beast stones? What kind of reasoning is that?" Rong Jin still had residual anger on his face. "I naturally don't want to associate with such fellow disciples!"

"Yiyi, let's go. Without them, we can still find beast stones ourselves." Rong Jin swept aside the vines blocking his face and strode into the dense forest.

"Senior Brother Rong Jin is right." Liu Wenzhu said softly, slipping her soft hand into Ning Fuyi's palm. "We've been like this since childhood. I'll always stay with you."

The warmth from the woman's fingertips reached her, and Ning Fuyi's lips relaxed. That warmth seemed to flow into her heart.

What long-missed love, making her almost have the illusion of wanting to cry.

Her eyelashes drooped, hiding the softness in her eyes. Suddenly she turned her head and smiled cunningly: "Wenzhu, Senior Brother, come with me."

After half the time it takes to burn a stick of incense, the three of them had already appeared inside Tongchuan<sup>1</sup>. There was moss everywhere here, and as far as the eye could see was all green. The green plants extended all the way to the surrounding towering tree trunks. Those trees of unknown names were each as wide as two arm-spans, coiling upward toward the sky, making it feel like being at the bottom of a well.

Liu Wenzhu and Rong Jin followed Ning Fuyi all the way, watching her search around in front of them. Rong Jin wanted to ask several times what Ning Fuyi was looking for, but never asked.

"Since we can't get first place anyway, just let her play around." Liu Wenzhu tugged on Rong Jin's sleeve.

"That makes sense." Rong Jin nodded.

"Found it, right here." Ning Fuyi suddenly called out loudly. She pointed at the ground with her foot. This was a huge clearing with chaos on the ground, vaguely resembling giant beast footprints.

"Looks like a mid-level spirit beast, quite large." Rong Jin quickly gripped his bow and arrows tightly. "Be careful."

"This place has many spirit beast tracks, proving there must be a nest nearby. Plus we passed a stream on our way here, and judging by the freshness of these footprints, they must be coming and going frequently to get water." Ning Fuyi said, suddenly leaping up, her toes touching a tree branch as her finger channeled a wisp of immortal power, pointing at the clearing below to draw an array formation.

"What kind of array is this? I've never seen it before." Liu Wenzhu stood on her tiptoes in surprise, looking at the patterns appearing on the ground below. Those patterns appeared for just a moment before disappearing into the soil.

"Never mind you, I've never seen it either." Rong Jin looked up at Ning Fuyi. "Fuyi, where did you learn this formation? Be careful not to hurt yourself!"

"Don't worry." The formation was already complete as she spoke. Ning Fuyi lightly leaped down from the treetop, her gaze looking around as if facing some difficulty.

"What's wrong?" Liu Wenzhu asked.

"It's fine, just that although we have a trap, we have no bait. How can we lure the spirit beasts over?" Ning Fuyi's phoenix eyes narrowed slightly, her gaze making a circle before landing on Rong Jin beside her.

Rong Jin was stunned.

So after another half stick of incense time, continuous beast roars echoed for hundreds of li around, mixed with a man's shouting, from far to near.

"Ning Fuyi!" Rong Jin's usually gentle and jade-like face was now full of dishevelment. He carried a blood-covered wild boar and ran frantically from the depths of the dense forest, shouting at the top of his lungs while leaping into the air as he approached the clearing.

So the several spirit beasts following him charged past and fell into the formation one after another. The scene was spectacular, like dumplings being dropped into boiling water. The spirit beasts that fell into the formation all roared angrily, then were bound by the formation and fell down with rigid bodies.

For a moment, mud and sand splattered everywhere, and leaves flew about.

Ning Fuyi and Liu Wenzhu concealed their auras and hid in the dense grass. Now they spat out the grass leaves from their mouths and stuck out their heads to look.

"Yiyi, your method is wonderful!" Liu Wenzhu looked at the spirit beasts entering the formation, her face flushed red with excitement. "There are quite a few mid-level spirit beasts in there."

"Isn't this much faster than hunting them one by one?" Ning Fuyi smiled with curved lips, reaching out to pick some wild fruits from the bushes and handing them to Liu Wenzhu.

"Senior Brother, continue!" she shouted loudly.

Rong Jin was covered in wild boar blood, his hair full of leaves. He spat out the sand from his mouth, slowly descended from the sky, pointed at Ning Fuyi and Liu Wenzhu for a long time, finally said "shameless," then angrily flicked his sleeves and continued to act as bait.

In this way, they only used half an hour and gained a full bag of beast stones. Seeing that Rong Jin was exhausted and out of breath, the three finally withdrew the formation and sat down on the spot.

"Here, Senior Brother, this is yours. Wenzhu, this is yours." Ning Fuyi sat cross-legged, distributing the beast stones divided into three portions to them respectively.

"This method is indeed good. Although there are no high-level spirit beasts, as long as we have enough beast stones, we might still be able to rank." Rong Jin finally wiped the blood off his body. "Let's rest and then continue."

Ning Fuyi nodded and got up to pat the mud off her skirt: "We need to find another place. The spirit beasts nearby already know there's a formation here, so fewer and fewer spirit beasts can be lured."

Liu Wenzhu and Rong Jin both agreed, so the three packed up their hunted beast stones and carefully walked toward deeper areas.

The closer to the center of Tongchuan, the more high-level spirit beasts and even demonic beasts there would be, so the three no longer joked around but walked carefully in silence.

However, after walking for only a short while, Ning Fuyi sensed something was wrong, and Liu Wenzhu beside her also spoke up.

"I keep feeling a chill on my back, as if someone is watching us." Liu Wenzhu said in a low voice, involuntarily reaching into her sleeve to grip her magical artifact.

"I feel it too. Someone is following us." Rong Jin also lowered his voice, extending his hand to shield Ning Fuyi and Liu Wenzhu behind him while taking out his longbow. "And their cultivation is extremely high. I can't determine their location at all."

At the same time, outside the Chaotic Realm, half the disciples had already been eliminated and returned to the high platform looking dejected, so the high platform became lively again.

"Sect Leader, look quickly!" Elder Sonxiang<sup>2</sup> of Tianji Sword Sect suddenly called out loudly, pointing toward the ink writing on one side of the arched door that displayed names and the number of beast stones obtained. "The people from Guijian Sect<sup>3</sup> have surpassed us."

People from Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate also noticed the anomaly. Elder Pingyao's brows furrowed like rope as she couldn't help but stand up.

"What's happening? Hong Ying and Feng Ge's beast stones were in second place, how did this Guijian Sect suddenly surpass us?" she said in surprise.

"The increase in others' beast stones follows a pattern, but theirs fell from the sky." Elder Yuanming, who was eating grapes nearby, spoke as if he was used to seeing such things. "Elder Pingyao, please don't worry. This Guijian Sect has always had dirty tricks. They probably robbed them from other sects again."

"But our Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate is not easy to bully either. Please don't worry." Elder Yuanming smiled. "Look, that child Ning Fuyi's beast stones are actually increasing quite well, leaving other sects behind by quite a bit."

"At least she's showing some backbone." Elder Pingyao exhaled and felt somewhat calmer.

But after a while, she stood up again: "I should still go pay respects to the Zhaoyang Saintess and report the situation to her. If this continues, what fairness will there be in the Zhaoyang Conference?"

"Elder, please wait." Elder Yuanming blocked her with his fan. "Let me go instead. I often come to Zhaoyang Mountain and know where the Saintess is in seclusion."

With that, he turned to Chu Qingqiu: "Divine Venerable, I'll be right back."

Chu Qingqiu's fingertips on the table contracted slightly, then she hummed in response, her gaze returning to the arched door, her eyes growing deeper.

---

## Footnotes:

1. **Tongchuan (铜川)** - A dangerous mountainous region known for its spirit beasts and magical creatures
2. **Elder Sonxiang (松香长老)** - "Pine Fragrance Elder," an elder from Tianji Sword Sect
3. **Guijian Sect (鬼见宗)** - "Ghost Sight Sect," one of the six major cultivation sects, known for underhanded methods

